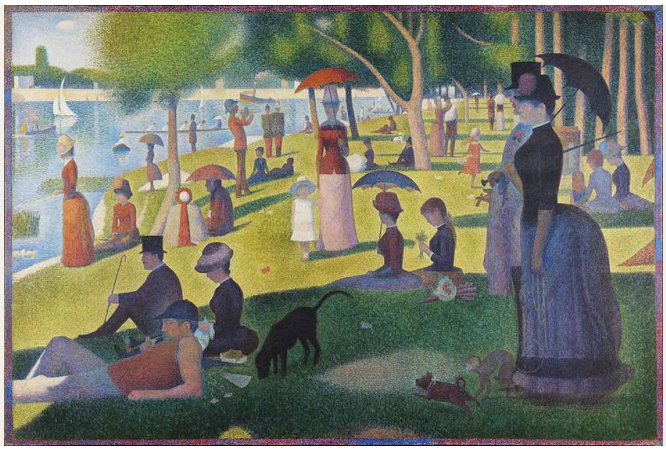
CHICAGO, UNITED STATES

Art Institute of Chicago: Masterpieces

Twenty works that organise public life and private surroundings in sharply different ways.



Seurat’s riverbank is crowded yet remarkably still. Hopper’s diner is brightly visible from an almost empty street, but its glass keeps the spectator outside. Caillebotte’s pedestrians pass close beneath umbrellas while a broad city recedes behind them. Each painting makes shared space available in a different way: as an arrangement, a separation or an encounter that is about to pass.

The domestic scenes and still lifes continue that inquiry on a smaller scale. A washing basin brings two bodies together; a bedroom tilts its furnishings toward the eye; a tabletop refuses to align perfectly. Familiar places and things need not produce a single, dependable viewpoint.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/art-institute-chicago

The selection · 20

1. A Sunday on La Grande Jatte—1884
   Georges Seurat · 1884–86, border added 1888–89
2. Nighthawks
   Edward Hopper · 1942
3. American Gothic
   Grant Wood · 1930
4. The Bedroom
   Vincent van Gogh · 1889
5. At the Moulin Rouge
   Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec · 1892–95
6. Paris Street; Rainy Day
   Gustave Caillebotte · 1877
7. The Child’s Bath
   Mary Cassatt · 1893
8. The Basket of Apples
   Paul Cézanne · c. 1893
9. Sky above Clouds IV
   Georgia O'Keeffe · 1965
10. The Song of the Lark
    Jules Breton · 1884
11. Bathers by a River
    Henri Matisse · 1909–10, 1913, and 1916–17
12. A Peasant Woman Digging before Her Cottage
    Vincent van Gogh · c. 1885
13. The Herring Net
    Winslow Homer · 1885
14. The Drinkers
    Vincent van Gogh · 1890
15. Acrobats at the Cirque Fernando
    Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1879
16. Amédée-David, Comte de Pastoret
    Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres · 1823–26
17. Arlésiennes: Mistral
    Paul Gauguin · 1888
18. Armida Encounters the Sleeping Rinaldo
    Giovanni Battista Tiepolo · c. 1742–45
19. Arrival of the Normandy Train, Gare Saint-Lazare
    Claude Monet · 1877
20. Blue and Green Music
    Georgia O'Keeffe · 1919–21

01 / 20

A Sunday on La Grande Jatte—1884

Georges Seurat

1884–86, border added 1888–89 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Georges Seurat. A Sunday Afternoon on the Island of La Grande Jatte. Image credit: Georges Seurat. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The people’s sharply separated profiles remain still against a surface of small dots and strokes. Seeing the gathering and seeing its construction are different tasks: the marks that divide the surface also sustain the larger arrangement. Seurat makes a public day beside the river appear carefully held, rather than caught in the middle of casual motion.

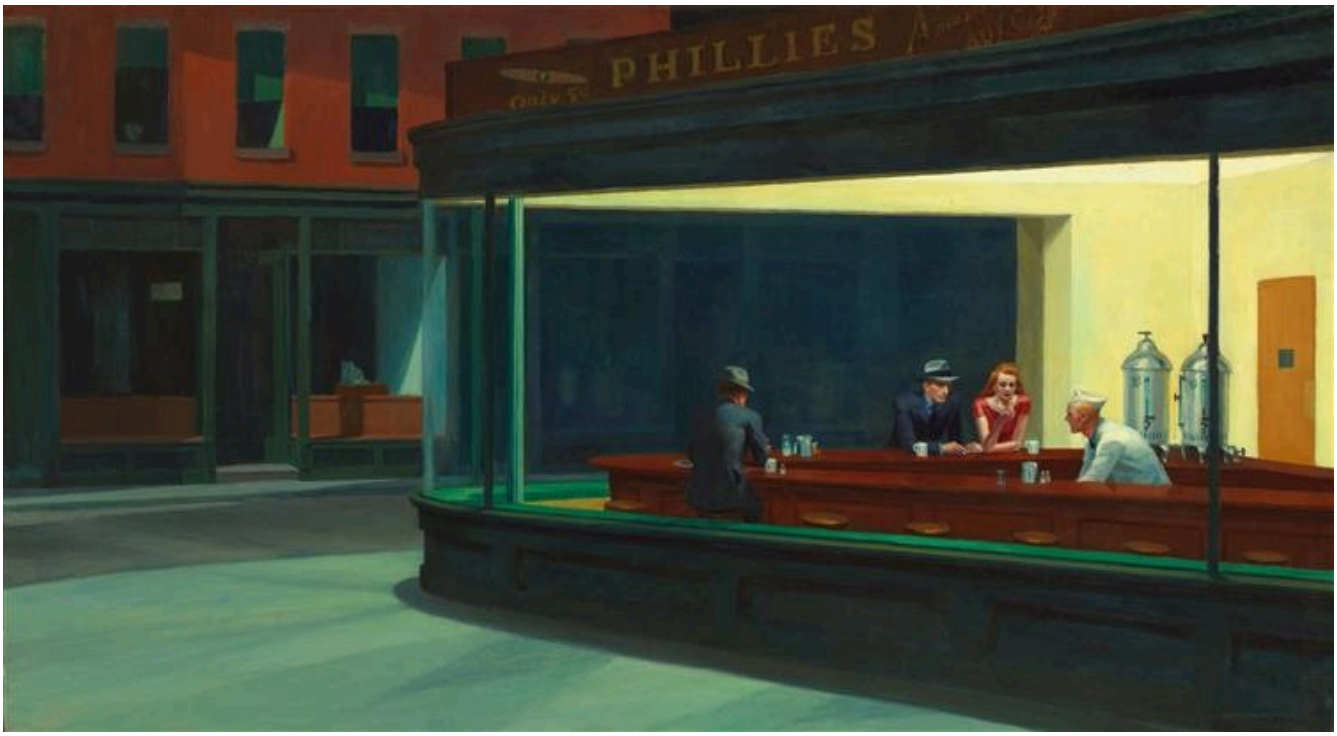
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1926.224

02 / 20

Nighthawks

Edward Hopper

1942 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Edward Hopper. Nighthawks. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The diner’s light makes its occupants plainly visible while the surrounding streets remain dark. Glass offers access to the scene through looking, not entry. The spectator occupies the outside of that relation. Hopper can establish separation without needing to assign the same private emotion to every customer or to the server.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1942.51

03 / 20

American Gothic

Grant Wood

1930 · Oil on beaver board · Art Institute of Chicago



Grant Wood. American Gothic. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The pitchfork, clothing and pointed window repeat upright forms across figures and house. That deliberate structure gives the pair’s stiffness a larger setting. Wood’s image need not be resolved into either approval or mockery of rural life. The poses and expressions sustain a more complicated encounter than a single verdict can account for.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1930.934

04 / 20

The Bedroom

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Vincent van Gogh. The Bedroom. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The bed, chairs and wall pictures are familiar, but the sloping room makes their relations less settled. Strong outlines hold the coloured areas apart while placement gives the furnishings character. This 1889 version returns to an earlier composition; repetition belongs to its making, rather than proving that a new bedroom stood before the painter.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1926.417

05 / 20

At the Moulin Rouge

Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec

1892–95 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec. At the Moulin Rouge. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The green-lit face at the edge interrupts the possibility of a comfortably unified group portrait. Mirrors, moving figures and the table's gathering offer different directions of attention under artificial light. Toulouse-Lautrec makes the room an uneven place to see and be seen, with cropping allowing some people far more abrupt access to the foreground than others.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1928.610

06 / 20

Paris Street; Rainy Day

Gustave Caillebotte

1877 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Gustave Caillebotte. Paris Street; Rainy Day. Gustave Caillebotte; Art Institute of Chicago; Charles H. and Mary F. S. Worcester Collection. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The lamppost gives the broad street a clear division, but the nearby couple brings a less predictable encounter into that order. Umbrellas accompany other pedestrians across the wet paving. Architecture can organise the distance without governing every movement through it; the city’s measured space remains subject to people passing close.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1964.336

07 / 20

The Child’s Bath

Mary Cassatt

1893 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Mary Cassatt. The Child's Bath. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The woman’s support and the washing of the child’s foot form one practical sequence. The basin and the bodies’ curves remain closely related from the high viewpoint, while patterned fabric surrounds them. Cassatt makes care legible through how weight is held and a task performed, rather than relying on a declared sentimental meaning.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1910.2

08 / 20

The Basket of Apples

Paul Cézanne

c. 1893 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Paul Cézanne. The Basket of Apples. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Individual apples, bottle and biscuits have convincing presence, yet the table’s edges do not align into one faultless space. The tilted basket and folded cloth keep further relations in play. Cézanne allows local solidity and overall instability to coexist, asking colour and shape to hold together what a single viewpoint does not fully reconcile.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1926.252

09 / 20

Sky above Clouds IV

Georgia O'Keeffe

1965 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Georgia O'Keeffe. Sky Above Clouds IV. WikiArt source label: Georgia O'Keeffe Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georgia-o-keeffe/sky-above-clouds-iv-1965 · Georgia O'Keeffe Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

White forms repeat toward a narrow pink horizon, with blue intervals separating them. Their continuation beyond the side edges makes the arrangement seem more extensive than the bounded canvas can contain. O’Keeffe gives the aerial subject a scale and rhythm different from a landscape organised around trees, buildings or a person standing on the ground.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1983.821

10 / 20

The Song of the Lark

Jules Breton

1884 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Jules Breton. The Song of the Lark. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The sickle is at rest while the woman’s face turns upward. The title identifies a moment of listening, but the tool and bare feet keep it within the agricultural day. The pause matters because work remains present: attention has shifted without the picture needing to remove the worker from her field.

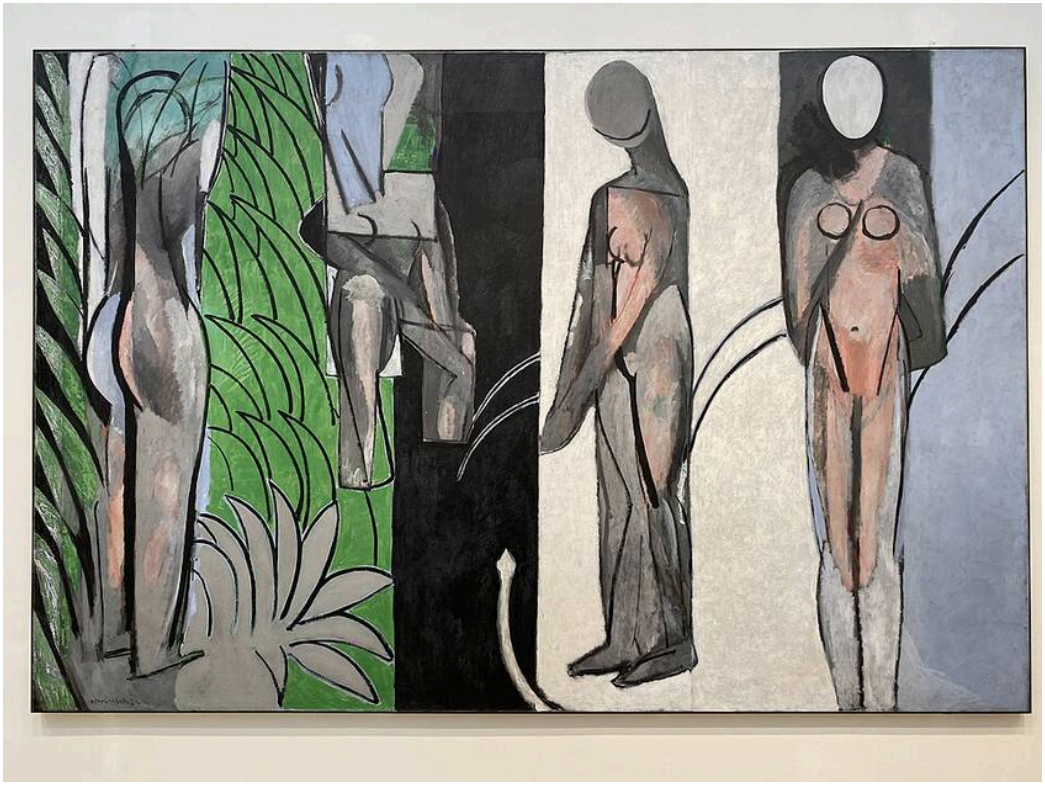
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1894.1033

11 / 20

Bathers by a River

Henri Matisse

1909–10, 1913, and 1916–17 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Henri Matisse. Bathers by a River. Image credit: Henri Matisse; Source credit: Own work https://www.artic.edu/artworks/79307/bathers-by-a-river. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Four bodies occupy strongly divided vertical areas, their faces reduced and their surroundings stylised. Their separation does as much work as the common subject of bathing. The composition underwent revisions across several years; its severe arrangement should not be mistaken for an effortless first decision or a single unchanging phase of work.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1953.158

12 / 20

A Peasant Woman Digging before Her Cottage

Vincent van Gogh

c. 1885 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Vincent van Gogh. A Peasant Woman Digging in Front of Her Cottage. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The woman’s bent posture belongs to the ground beside the low cottage. Muted colour connects body, soil and roof without dissolving their different forms. Home and labour remain close: shelter is part of the same small setting in which the earth must be worked, rather than an escape presented elsewhere in the picture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1968.92

13 / 20

The Herring Net

Winslow Homer

1885 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Winslow Homer. The Herring Net. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The net's weight is made visible through two fishermen's coordinated effort. Their small boat must carry both the catch and the work of raising it while the water continues to move. Homer keeps the sea active in the task. Skill does not remove the unstable conditions under which it has to operate.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1937.1039

14 / 20

The Drinkers

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Vincent van Gogh. The Drinkers. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Men lift vessels around a table as a child stands near the gathering. Curved strokes give bodies and ground a related activity. Van Gogh reworks an image by Daumier, so the picture is useful for considering copying as a practice: another artist’s arrangement can be retained while colour and handling change its pictorial character.

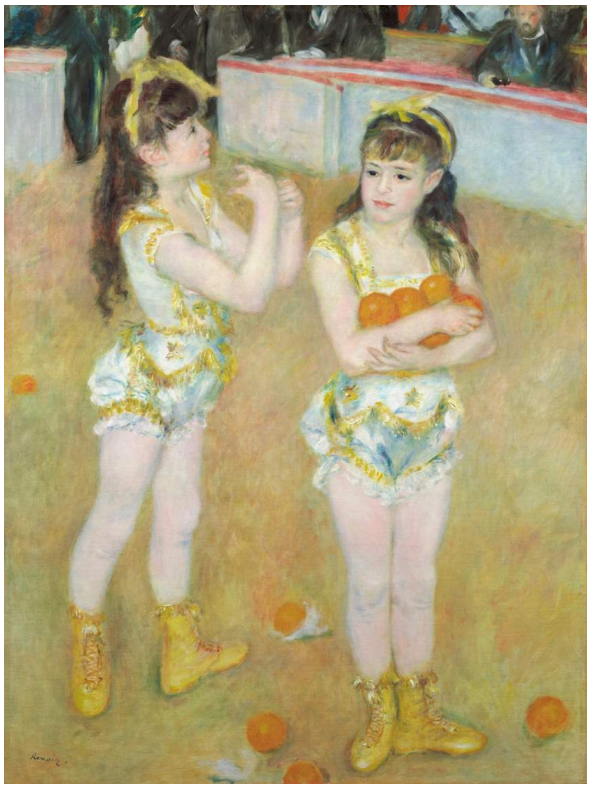
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1953.178

15 / 20

Acrobats at the Cirque Fernando

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1879 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Acrobats at the Cirque Fernando (Francisca and Angelina Wartenberg). Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The young performers stand on the circus floor without being shown at the height of an acrobatic feat. Costume, fruit and raised hands retain the circumstances of public entertainment. Renoir gives the interval after or around performance its own bodily presence, keeping the figures from becoming only demonstrations of what they can do.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1922.440

16 / 20

Amédée-David, Comte de Pastoret

Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres

1823–26 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Jean-Auguste-Dominique Ingres. Amédée-David, the Comte de Pastoret. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The sitter’s body, desk and enclosing green drapery maintain a carefully controlled relation. Few details are allowed to compete with face, hand and formal clothing. Ingres builds public standing from those selected elements rather than a crowd of attributes, making the exact disposition of the body consequential.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1971.452

17 / 20

Arlésiennes: Mistral

Paul Gauguin

1888 · Oil on jute canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Paul Gauguin. Arlésiennes (Mistral). Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The women’s dark, joined silhouettes move through a landscape broken by trees and emphatic colour areas. Their bent heads make the movement readable even where space does not form an uninterrupted route. Gauguin keeps a recognisable group while allowing pattern to reorganise the conditions through which it passes.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1934.391

18 / 20

Armida Encounters the Sleeping Rinaldo

Giovanni Battista Tiepolo

c. 1742–45 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Giovanni Battista Tiepolo. Armida Encounters the Sleeping Rinaldo. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The sleeping man cannot return the attention of the richly dressed woman approaching him. His still body provides a firm point amid flying fabric and small surrounding figures. Tiepolo makes unequal awareness the encounter's central condition, while the lighter movement around it delays any sense that the scene has settled.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1925.700

19 / 20

Arrival of the Normandy Train, Gare Saint-Lazare

Claude Monet

1877 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Claude Monet. Arrival of the Normandy Train, Gare Saint-Lazare. Art Institute of Chicago. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The glazed roof and iron supports give the station a large enclosing structure. Steam interrupts its clarity, partly hiding the train and filtering the light around scattered figures. Monet treats the industrial interior as a place whose atmosphere changes, rather than assuming machinery must always be presented through hard, equally visible outlines.

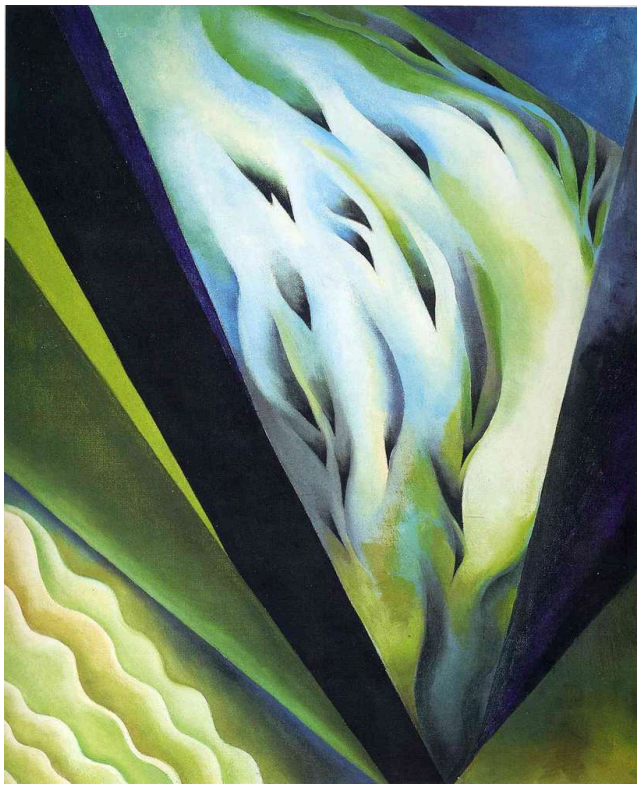
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1933.1158

20 / 20

Blue and Green Music

Georgia O'Keeffe

1919–21 · Oil on canvas · Art Institute of Chicago



Georgia O'Keeffe. Blue and Green Music. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georgia-o-keeffe/blue-and-green-music · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

No instrument or performer explains the title. Curving blue, green and pale bands offer direction and recurrence, interrupted by darker wedges. O’Keeffe gives the painting’s musical association visual grounds without pretending that colour can be translated into a fixed sequence of notes. Its movement belongs to the relations on the surface.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1969.835

Compare how a shared place is held together

Begin with the riverbank, the diner and the rainy street, then reduce the scale to Cassatt's basin or Cézanne's table. The question changes with the setting: who can enter, what supports a body, and which edges can be trusted? Consult current Art Institute listings for display availability; this is an editorial selection rather than a room route.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

The Metropolitan Museum's exhibition catalogue gives historical context for Seurat, Caillebotte, Cassatt, Monet and their contemporaries. Its varied examples help distinguish different approaches that a single label such as Impressionism can otherwise flatten.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Art Institute of Chicago: Masterpieces